

What are Opinions? Integrating Theory and Methods for Automatically Analyzing Opinionated Communication (OPINION)



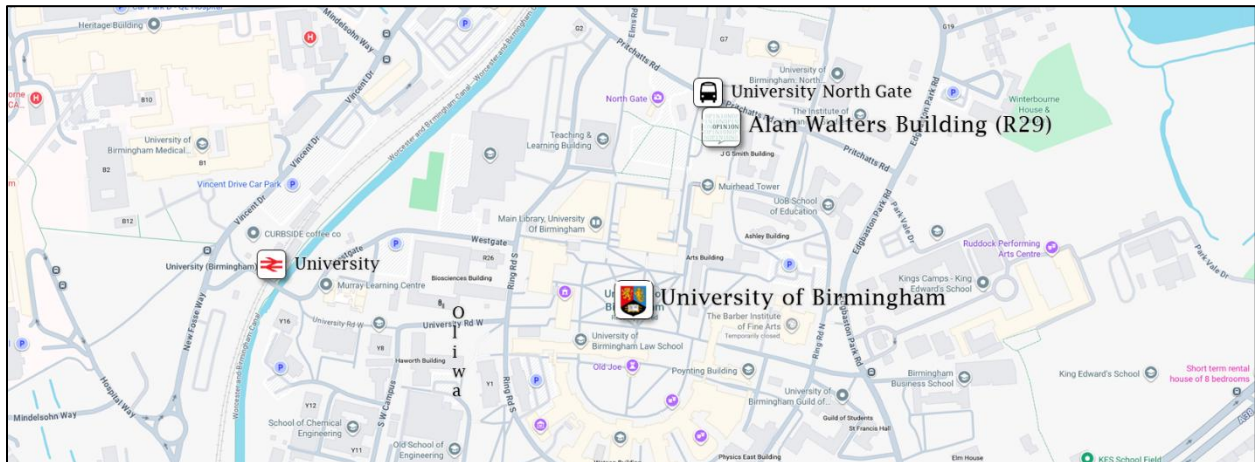
THE NEXT GENERATION OF TEXTUAL OPINION RESEARCH

OPINION Preconference before the 2026 CompText Annual Meeting

University of Birmingham

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2 PROGRAM

Wednesday, 22 April 2026

09:00-09:30 *Arrival & Coffee*

09:30-11:00 **Works in Progress I: Cross-lingual Studies of Opinionated Discourse**

Chair: Christian Baden, The Hebrew U of Jerusalem, Israel

- Analysis of the most frequent collocates in electronic national language corpora as indicators of collective tendencies in thinking
Mirjana Ilic, U of Nis, Serbia
Respondents: Barbara Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk, Jurate Ruzaite
- The role of political catchwords in opinion discourse: A cross-national and cross-disciplinary study
Ema Kristo, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania
Muhamet Jahiri, U of Prishtina, Kosovo
Larisa Mistrean, Academy of Economic Studies of Moldova, Moldova
Respondents: Carlos Cunha
- Parliamentary speech analysis: Cooperation with China vs. Talking about China
Jelena Gledic, University of Belgrade, Serbia
Respondents: Ana Jovancevic, Ledia Kazazi
- Measuring the framing of ICE in international news media with LLMs
Peter Maurer, Karlstad U, Sweden
Jamal Abdul Nasir, U of Galway, Ireland
Ofer Shinar, Ruppin Academic Center, Israel
Respondents: Elena Negrea Busuioc, Aleksandra Urman

11:00-11:30 *Coffee*

11:30-13:00 **Works in Progress II: Methodological Issues in Opinion Measurement**

Chair: Damian Trilling, Vrije U Amsterdam, The Netherlands

- Introducing and Advancing {sentiner}. A Tool for Targeted Sentiment Analysis in Comparative Political Research
Daniel Thiele, Freie U Berlin, Germany
Baoning Gong, Freie U Berlin, Germany
Respondents: Johannes B. Gruber, Damian Trilling
- Gender Representation in Large Language Models: A Cross-Linguistic and Cross-Model Analysis
Dren Gërguri, U of Prishtina, Kosovo
Aleksandra Urman, U of Zurich, Switzerland
Emese Domahidi, U of Ilmenau, Germany
Johannes B. Gruber, GESIS, Germany
Ana Jovancevic, U of Limerick, Ireland
Michaela Maier, RPTU Landau, Germany
Jaromir Mazak, STEM Institute for Empirical Research, Czechia
Respondents: Jamal Nasir, Jelena Gledic

- Ambivalence as stance: Interpreting 'unclear' positions in debates on trans issues online

Jurate Ruzaitė, Vytautas Magnus U, Lithuania

Elena Negrea-Busuioc, State U of Political Studies & Pub. Adm., Romania

Andrius Utkas, Vytautas Magnus U, Lithuania

Barbara Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk, State U of Appl. Sc. Konin, Poland

Ledia Kazazi, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania

Ardita Dylgjeri, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania

Anna Baczkowska, U of Gdansk, Poland

Respondents: Christian Baden, Peter Maurer

13:00-14:00 *Lunch*

14:00-15:30 **Future Research I: Tracking Opinion on Political Controversy**

Chair: Carlos Cunha, Lisbon U Institute, Portugal

- Opinion, Normativity, and Public Mandate: Computational Analysis of Expressed Opinion in Public Service Media

Ardita Reci, U of Durrës Aleksandër Moisiu, Albania

- Social Media Opinions on the European Union in Member States and Candidate Countries: An Interdisciplinary Computational-Discourse Approach

Ledia Kazazi, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania

- Rising Sea Level Refugees and Civil Society Discourses: Framing Public Opinion with topic modeling [*presenter absent, might be canceled*]

Anna Baczkowska, U of Gdansk, Poland

Barbara Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk, State U of Appl. Sc. Konin, Poland

Ardita Dylgjeri, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania

Ledia Kazazi, U of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani, Albania

Erika Lombart, U of Namur, Belgium

Aleksandra Chmarzynska, U of Gdansk, Poland

Konrad Radomyski, U of Gdansk, Poland

Chaya Liebeskind, Jerusalem College of Technology, Israel

15:30-16:00 *Coffee*

16:00-17:30 **Future Research II: Advancing New Strategies for Opinion Research**

Chair: Christian Baden, The Hebrew U of Jerusalem, Israel

- Systematic Evaluation of Large Language Model Biases in Political Ideology Classification

Aleksandra Urman, U of Zurich, Switzerland

Johannes B. Gruber, GESIS, Germany

- Bridging the Computational-Qualitative Divide in Opinion research

Damian Trilling, Vrije U Amsterdam, The Netherlands

- Silicon Sampling: Validating LLMs as Synthetic Benchmarks for Opinion Analysis

Enes Abanoz, Ondukuz Mayıs U, Türkiye

Özlem Delal Abanoz, Ondukuz Mayıs U, Türkiye

3 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: Before the meeting

Travel

Participants are required to make their own travel arrangements, the costs for which will be reimbursed afterwards, subject to the rules detailed below.

To get to Birmingham from Birmingham International Airport, there is a direct train to the city center (Birmingham New Street Station).

You may also arrive via the London airports: From London Heathrow and London Gatwick, you can travel via London Euston Station or use the direct National Express coach services; from London Luton, there is a bus to Milton Keynes, where you can catch a train to Birmingham (total travel time: 2 ½ to 3 hours for all routes). From Manchester airport, you can catch a train at Stockport or again use the National Express coaches (ca. 2 hours).

The University of Birmingham's Main Campus is located in the South of the city. The preconference venue is in the Alan Waters Building (R29 in the university directory), just North of the central ring of buildings on the main campus.



The closest train station is University Station, which is served by West Midlands Railway trains toward Redditch, Worcester, and Hereford (~7 min from New Street Station). From there, follow the signs towards university campus, which leads you over a bridge crossing the canal. Walk straight towards the library and the Green Heart and turn left to walk uphill towards North Gate. The building is to your right.

Alternatively, you can take bus routes X20, X21 or X22 from Birmingham New Street Station (St Martin's Queensway) in the city center (~15 min). Alight at University North Gate, which is a 2-minute walk from Alan Walters Building.

Current public transport timetables are available via Google Maps, on the National Rail website (<https://tinyurl.com/2s485yj3>) for trains, or the NX Bus West Midlands website (<https://nxbus.co.uk/west-midlands>) for buses. Single tickets cost between £3 and £4. Train tickets can be purchased at ticket machines, using contactless or chip-and-pin cards. Bus tickets can be purchased on the bus either via contactless or with cash (coins only, no change given). Bus tickets are capped at £5.20 per day if paid via contactless (provided that you use the same card for multiple trips).

If you need a taxi, you can use Uber or Bolt. A trip to the city center costs around £10, while a trip from the University to the airport costs around £35. Alternatively, T.O.A Taxis, a local taxi company, can be reached on +44(0) 121 427 8888.

Accommodation

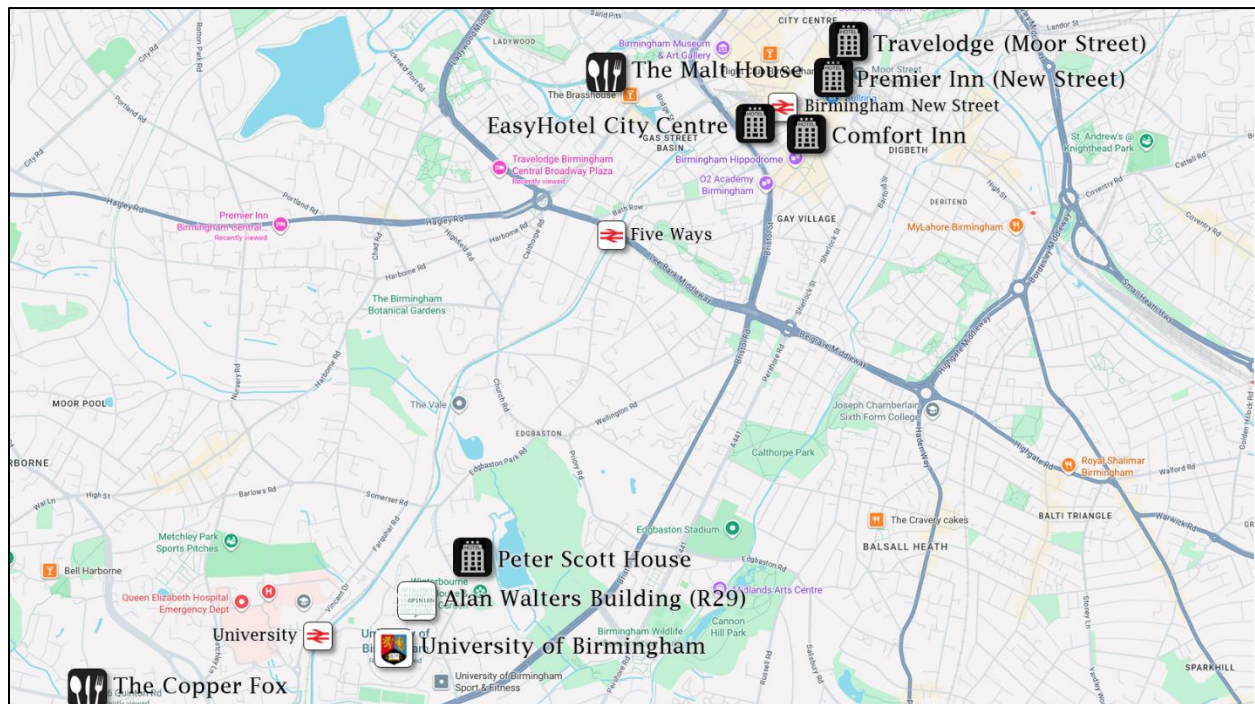
Participants need to arrange their own accommodation, the costs for which will be reimbursed afterwards, subject to the rules detailed below.

For participants who require accommodation in Birmingham, we recommend staying at one of the following hotels, which offer decent quality at reasonable cost (ordered by distance; most hotels are located around New Street Station, with direct train or bus connections to the venue). If you choose something different, that is up to you.

- **Peter Scott House** (~5 min walk): from €170
to book: <https://www.edgbastonparkhotel.com/conference-room/peter-scott-house/>
- **Easy Hotel Birmingham City Centre**: (~15 min by public transport): from €90
to book: <https://tinyurl.com/vc76k57f>
- **Comfort Inn Birmingham** (~15 min by public transport): from €100
to book: <https://tinyurl.com/mrcwn5xy>
- **Premier Inn Birmingham (New Street)** (~15 min by public transport): from €125
to book: <https://www.premierinn.com/gb/en/home.html>
- **Travelodge Birmingham (Moor Street)** (~20 min by public transport): from €55
to book: <https://tinyurl.com/2j4ad8p6>

You may also choose to check options on AirBnB.

The below map shows the location of all hotels and venues.



4 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: During the meeting

Attendance Lists

In order to receive reimbursements for your expenses, you are required to confirm your participation via e-COST prior to the event, and to document your participation by signing the attendance list. If you do not sign the attendance list, we will not be able to reimburse you, so please make sure you do not forget this. Please note that separate attendance lists will be available for each day of the program, so if you attend the entire duration of the meeting, you will need to sign multiple times.

Wifi

For the duration of the Working Group meeting, you will be able to connect to the eduroam Wifi network of University of Birmingham. In case you have any issues connecting to eduroam, please connect to UoB Guest Wifi (no password required).

Coffee & Lunch

Coffee, tea, juice and water as well as snacks and biscuits will be offered during breaks in the program.

For lunch (self-paid), there is a café in the same building, and there are several convenient outside options nearby (supermarkets, pubs, food carts, etc.).

Dinner

We are organizing a joint dinner on Wednesday evening at *The Copper Fox Grill (156 Quinton Road, ~15 minutes by bus or a 30-minute walk from the venue)*. Participation is voluntary and self-paid; however, we ask you to confirm your participation two weeks prior to the event at the latest, so we can make reservations.

Informal Get-Together on the evening before

All participants who are already in town on Tuesday evening are warmly invited to join an informal, self-paid get-together, starting around 7 pm at *The Malt House* (75 King Edwards Road) in the city center.

5 PRACTICAL INFORMATION: After the meeting

Reimbursement

According to COST rules, all reimbursements will be processed after the meeting.

We can reimburse only participants who:

- a) were invited to physically attend the meeting, eligible to be reimbursed;
- b) confirmed their attendance via the eCOST system prior to the meeting;
- c) actually attended the network meeting, as documented by signing the attendance lists available at each session;
- d) submitted their reimbursement claims within 14 days after the meeting, via the eCOST system (you will receive an email once the meeting has ended).

Any long-distance travel costs (>100km) will be reimbursed at the value stated on presented tickets, up to a maximum of 1,500 Euro. Participants are expected to book well in time, as soon as you have received your formal invitation (so please avoid last minute bookings) and use economic connections (within reason, nobody expects you to take a train in the middle of the night or fly with three layovers), and book well in time to avoid unnecessary costs. You may include cancellation insurance, the costs for which will be refunded as part of the ticket. If you use a private car for part of the way, costs are covered at 0.35 EUR/km, up to 2000 km – but please then make sure to keep documentation of the timeline of this part of the trip. **New: To document that you arrived by car, COST wants to see a parking ticket that clearly indicates the date and location of parking (electronic receipts, such as screenshots of SMS confirmations, are accepted); or, if parking is free, a written declaration by the parking provider, such as the hotel or venue.**

You can also claim expenses for visa processing fees if you needed to obtain a visa specifically for attending the network meeting. Such costs will be reimbursed at the value stated on presented receipts or documentation. This does not include any costs related to visa obtained for purposes beyond the network meeting.

All (!) other costs (i.e., accommodation, local transportation <100km, food etc.) are covered by a flat daily allowance, which for the United Kingdom amounts to 236 Euro per full day. The daily allowance takes into account your actual travel time from and to your place of origin, not only the day of the event itself. For instance, if you travel to Birmingham on Sunday afternoon and return on Tuesday night, you will be eligible for roughly two and a half days' worth of daily allowance, or three if you arrive at home only in the next morning.

Please note that we will not disburse daily allowances for the time that you spent traveling for reasons unrelated to the network meeting: If you put in additional days in the United Kingdom for your own reasons, that's up to you, but we will then only

consider the time that you would have spent traveling without such intermissions toward your daily allowance.

Please note also that, if you arrive from or continue to a destination other than your home institution, we will ask you to explain that in your reimbursement claim. If you travel to multiple destinations, we will only refund your travel costs from the preceding and to the next destination and assume that any other legs of your trip are motivated by other purposes and covered otherwise. You are required to avoid double funding. Claiming reimbursement for expenses that are covered by other sources will be considered a violation of COST rules.

For the full COST rules on travel reimbursements, please consult this document: https://www.cost.eu/travel_reimbursement_rules

Also note that it is your responsibility to keep your bank contact data in your COST profile up to date, and to submit your receipts and refund claims within two weeks after the meeting.

Claiming your Reimbursement: Updated Procedure!

Following a reorganization of the processing of reimbursement claims at the VU Amsterdam, our grant holding organization, **you will need to fill in not one, but two forms:**

- 1) the **e-COST form**, to file your claim and calculate what you are eligible to receive
- 2) a **VU payment form**, which will be sent to you by our Grant Manager, Aysen Simsek

Until you fill in the second form, please **hold on to all receipts and documents** from your travel, not only those you need for the e-COST form, just in case.

This is the process:

Please fill in the e-COST form first, within 14 days at most after the meeting. Once you have digitally signed your claim (you receive an email from the system, please keep that email), you can download a PDF confirmation of your claim, which you need to keep. You will later need to attach this PDF to your VU form, and you can use it to copy the correct data for into that form later.

Importantly, **don't delete your documentation after filling in the e-COST form, you will need it again for the second form!** We also recommend to create one PDF file right away with all the documentation that you just uploaded to e-COST.

Your claims will then be checked first by us and then by COST (this typically takes two, three weeks, although things may take longer if there are questions or issues).

Once we hand over the checked and COST-approved claims to the VU, our grant manager will contact you with a VU Reference Number (starting R/...) and the link to their payments form. In the form, you then need to fill in:

- 1) your **personal details** (everything marked *; please make sure your email is correct, so the VU can contact you if necessary)
- 2) your **bank details** (IBAN and SWIFT/BIC if possible, you can find your IBAN here: <https://ibancalculator.com>; if your SWIFT/BIC is shorter than 11 digits, fill up with XX on the right; you should be able to copy this from the confirmation PDF that e-COST sent you when you submitted that form. If needed, you should be able to find your account information also on your bank's website)
- 3) your **expense details** (everything marked *; you can copy most of this from the PDF that you downloaded when submitting the e-COST form), which include:
 - a. The VU reference number mentioned above
 - b. a short (<25 characters) and a longer description (the short one can be "travel costs to Birmingham" or similar, the longer might be something like "travel costs to OPINION preconference in Birmingham, as calculated by e-COST: flight [wherever you are] - Birmingham and back, 2 days Daily Allowance")
 - c. Select "Travel and Expenses" as Description, and "Travel and Expenses abroad" as type of expense.
 - d. Please select EUR as currency code, and enter the exact same amount that was calculated by the e-COST portal as amount.
- 4) your **expenses documentation**. For this, please attach the same documents that you uploaded to e-COST, merged into a single PDF file. The total file size should not exceed 3MB (so if the merged file gets too big, try to reduce the resolution in the PDF settings).
- 5) Please also attach a **copy of the confirmation email** that you received **and the PDF** that you downloaded upon submitting your claims via e-COST.

If you have any questions, please contact the Financial Service Center at the VU under +31(0)20-5983478 or servicedesk.fsc@vu.nl.

We apologize for the extra work; the good thing is that with this form, the VU should be able to actually pay out your reimbursement within ~2 weeks after you submit this second form, which would be faster than what we had in the past.

6 PARTICIPANTS

The Preconference includes 20 participants from 17 countries who will participate in person. The entire network presently comprises 236 members from 42 countries.

Name	Surname	Institution	Country
Enes	Abanoz	Ondokus Mayis U	Turkiye
Christian	Baden	The Hebrew U of Jerusalem	Israel
Carlos	Cunha	Lisbon U Institute	Portugal
Dren	Gerguri	U of Prishtina	Kosovo
Jelena	Gledic	U of Belgrade	Serbia
Johannes	Gruber	GESIS	Germany
Mirjana	Ilic	U of Nis	Serbia
Ana	Jovancevic	U of Limerick	Ireland
Ledia	Kazazi	University of Elbasan Aleksandër Xhuvani	Albania
Ema	Kristo	U of Tirana	Albania
Barbara	Lewandowska-Tomaszczyk	State U of Applied Sciences Konin	Poland
Peter	Maurer	Karlstad U	Sweden
Jamal	Nasir	U of Galway	Ireland
Elena	Negrea-Busuioc	National U of Political Studies & Public Admin.	Romania
Ardita	Reci	U of Durrës Aleksandër Moisiu	Albania
Jurate	Ruzaite	Vytautas Magnus U	Lithuania
Regina	Seiwald	U of Birmingham	United Kingdom
Daniel	Thiele	Freie U Berlin	Germany
Damian	Trilling	Vrije U Amsterdam	The Netherlands
Aleksandra	Urman	U of Zurich	Switzerland

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COST (European Cooperation in Science and Technology) is a funding agency for research and innovation networks. Our Actions help connect research initiatives across Europe and enable scientists to grow their ideas by sharing them with their peers. This boosts their research, career and innovation.